CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of The Study

Peace has been defined variably. According to Galtung (2021), peace transcends the mere absence of war or direct violence. Other scholars have elucidated this concept by underscoring that peace is a dynamic and ongoing process that incorporates concepts like structural violence, legal rights, environmental justice, unity, and inner disposition. For instance, children today no longer see schools as places to learn; instead, they see them as communities where values like unity and empathy are practiced and felt (Jabor & Palmos, 2025). Sapao & Dacles (2021) also contend that education attains significance when anchored in social and cultural realities, enabling learners to engage in peace as an interactive and participatory process. Mabunga (2021) elucidates that peace encompasses cognitive, emotional, and behavioral dimensions that foster nonviolence and reciprocal respect within institutions. Smieszek (2022) broadens this concept by incorporating climate justice and the safeguarding of solidarity rights as fundamental components of peace. Savelyeva and Park (2024) present the notion of an "ecology of peace," encompassing various dimensions (negative, positive, homeostatic, and futuristic). The meaning of peace is also variable in consideration of the context (Olivius & Akebo, 2021). For instance, peace in Sri Lanka after the war is very different from peace in Cambodia or South Africa. Taking these views as a whole all point to the idea that peace is more than just the absence of war. It's also about having fair, just, and long-lasting relationships between people, groups, and institutions. Schools and other places where people meet. So, they are essential for building peace as a personal virtue and as a social norm.

From a local perspective, Peace education gained heightened vitality in the Philippines due to the nation’s long history of internal conflicts, pervasive social inequality, and persistent regional tensions (Department of Education, 2022). The Philippine government, driven by its recognition of peace’s critical importance, has prioritize the institutional inclusion of peace education within the country’s educational framework. Case in point, the Department of Education (DepED) released the Peace Education Framework in 2022. This framework encourages

creative, inclusive ways to teach peace, such as using visual arts to promote empathy, diversity, and conflict resolution. In the same vein, the Commission on Higher Education (CHED) issued CMO No. 42, Series of 2021, requiring all higher education institutions in the Philippines to include peace education and related values in their general education curricula. Both DepEd Peace Education Framework and CHED CMO 42 emphasize the importance of integrating peace-oriented values into school life, aligning with global efforts to promote social justice and long-lasting peace through education (Floresta, 2022).

One of the more powerful medium in expressing and delivering statements for peace, inside and outside of the Philippines are Visual and public arts in which they have long been powerful ways to make political statements, protest, and get people involved in their communities. Community-based and collaborative art practices effectively enhance awareness of human rights, social injustices, and civic matters (University of the Philippines, 2024). Multiple studies indicate that learners enhance perceptual and aesthetic skills through visual projects. Their art often shows how they see and understand conflict and peace, and how they live and deal with social and cultural issues. These visual outputs offer significant insights for educators and researchers focused on peacebuilding. (Paterson, 2024). Blasch and Thoma (2024) assert that children employ multimodal combinations, including drawings, symbols, emojis, and text, to convey concepts of peace and war. These visual expressions convey nuance, creativity, and emotion, providing profound insights into children's perspectives. Arts-based research shows that drawings, posters, and murals can help us understand how young people think about peace. Visual narratives frequently encapsulate themes of community, spirituality, resilience, and hope, mirroring local cultural and contemporary issues (Lokola, 2024). Anderson (2024) contends that arts-based participatory methodologies facilitate students' articulation of their hopes and anxieties regarding societal issues. Structured art workshops, drawing sessions, and reflective "peace walls" promote dialogue and amplify youth voices.

Globally, Scholars have examined how children and adolescents convey peace through visual art. Gulec (2021) conducted a study utilizing children's drawings and interviews, indicating that peace is frequently represented by doves, flags, nature, and individuals holding hands. Similarly, Nadam (2023) examined the artwork of refugee children in Jordan and identified

recurring metaphors, including homes, sports, and the earth, which signify their emotional need for safety and belonging. Consequently, art-based methodologies have emerged as an essential component of peace education research (Anderson & Nesterova, 2024). Holochwost et al. (2021) contend that arts education facilitates children's socio-emotional development by enhancing empathy, self-regulation, and social awareness. These shows that art helps people grow emotionally and creatively, which is essential for getting along with others. Likewise, Jabor (2024) employed participatory photography to facilitate students' visual articulation of their perceptions of peace. Breed et al. (2024) assert that visual and performing arts reinforce community ties, empower disenfranchised youth, and cultivate a collective awareness of peace. Hazenberg et al. (2025) characterize arts-based peacebuilding as a social innovation process that fosters well-being, empathy, and inter-group trust through creative expression. Nesterova and Anderson (2024). Milican (2021) similarly demonstrated that visual exhibitions and collaborative art projects promote global citizenship and cross-cultural dialogue among university students. Haruna (2022) highlights the power of photography and murals as tools used by students and displaced communities to express their collective vision of peace, reconciliation, and environmental harmony. Paat (2022) discovered that arts-based activities foster kindness, diminish aggression, and encourage cooperation among learners. Research highlights the crucial role of the visual arts in peace education, serving as a medium for engaging youth in critical reflection and discourse on peace and justice (O'Connor & Hearn, 2023).

Consequently, the goal of this study is to capture and analyze students visual representation of peace; to identify and interpret the symbolism and meanings embedded in their artworks; to develop thematic insights drawn from student's accompanying narratives to explain their visual representations; and to provide actionable recommendations to strengthen peace education within the institution.

Meanwhile, the significance of the study lies in its contribution to understanding how students visually represent the concept of peace through their own creative expressions. By interpreting student's visual narratives, this research uncovers their perceptions, emotions, and values related to peace, harmony, and community life. In the end, the study stresses that peace is essential for both personal, communal, and social harmony. It amplifies student voices to

challenge and engage with the often-dominant mainstream narrative. Furthermore, its goal is to shape future educational practices that actively foster a genuinely peaceful and welcoming learning environment.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

This review of related literature analyzes the varied research that underpins the current study on students' visual representations of peace. The framework integrates domestic and global research on peace education, arts-based pedagogy, youth engagement, and the cultural interpretations of peace.

The most common, immediate understanding of peace is negative peace. This simply refers to the absence of direct, organized violence, such as the cessation of war between states, a ceasefire, or the lack of overt armed conflict within a country. It is a definition of peace based on the *lack* of something harmful (Dlewis, 2025).

The presence of insurgency is a clear and dramatic manifestation of the failure of negative peace. Insurgency is an organized armed resistance against a state's political authority, fundamentally representing a state of ongoing direct violence. While it may not be a large-scale international war, an insurgency signifies that a significant portion of the population is actively engaged in hostility, meaning the society has not achieved even the minimum condition of negative peace. A government might claim peace exists, but if an insurgency is active, that claim is instantly refuted by the continuous, visible disruption of law and order and the persistent use of force.

This is why scholars argue that negative peace alone is insufficient. When direct violence (like an insurgency) is absent, the society may only be experiencing a temporary truce enforced by repression or military might.

This brings us to positive peace. This concept moves beyond mere silence and refers to the presence of the conditions necessary for true, sustained stability. Positive peace is defined by

the existence of factors such as social justice, economic equity, political inclusion, and non-discriminatory governance. It focuses on dismantling structural violence—the systemic ways in which social, political, and economic structures harm people and prevent them from meeting their basic needs, which often fuels movements like insurgencies in the first place. Therefore, positive peace views a healthy society as one where everyone has dignity and opportunity (Kumar, 2025).

The concept of social peace is widely understood between negative peace the absence of direct violence and positive peace, which refers to the presence of social justice, inclusivity, and structures that support long-term human development (Galtung, 2021). In conflict-affected communities, achieving social peace requires not only stopping armed hostilities but also addressing the systemic and structural issues that give rise to conflict. This framework is highly relevant in the Philippine context, where communities previously affected by insurgency require both physical security and social transformation to attain lasting peace.

In the Philippines, the government's peace building framework under the Whole-of-Nation Approach, institutionalized through Executive Order No. 70, integrates these two forms of peace by combining security operations with socio-economic and governance reforms. This national strategy emphasizes convergent efforts among government agencies to address the root causes of armed rebellion and promote community development (Office of the Presidential Adviser on Peace, Reconciliation, and Unity (OPAPRU, 2019). Such policies reflect a shift from purely militaristic solutions toward a more comprehensive model of peacebuilding.

Insurgency in the Philippines has historically been driven by multi-dimensional issues such as poverty, inequity, weak local governance, and limited access to services. The presence of insurgent groups disrupts social order, weakens institutions, and heightens community insecurity conditions indicating a breakdown of negative peace. As a result, restoring negative peace requires both security operations and the reduction of conditions that enable insurgency to thrive. Security forces have employed a combination of community engagement and intelligence operations to dismantle guerrilla fronts.

A study profiling former rebels in 2020 showed that “hearts-and-minds” programs focusing on outreach, dialogue, and social assistance significantly undermined insurgent recruitment and encouraged surrenders (Journal News, 2021). These efforts contribute to restoring immediate stability, yet scholars emphasize that negative peace alone cannot produce lasting societal harmony. Pathways to Positive Social Peace Beyond the cessation of violence, peace becomes sustainable only when communities experience participation, justice, and development.

Recent empirical evidence from the Revitalized Pulis sa Barangay (R-PSB) program demonstrates how safety and development converge to build positive peace. In barangays previously influenced by insurgency, R-PSB interventions combining community policing, service delivery, and development programs improved public trust in government institutions and strengthened community cohesion (Padua et al., 2023). The study concluded that the presence of responsive institutions reduced residents’ vulnerability to insurgent influence and enabled greater community involvement in governance (Padua et al., 2023).

Positive peace is further reinforced by inclusive development efforts. The Mindanao Development Authority (MINDA) reported that since 2020, intensified socio-economic programs in conflict-affected communities such as livelihood support, infrastructure projects, and social protection services contributed to their gradual transition into “insurgency-free” zones (MINDA, 2025). These shows that long-term social peace is built not only through security but also through empowerment and equitable access to opportunities. Reintegration of Former Rebels and Community Healing The reintegration of ex-combatants is a crucial aspect of peace building, as it helps stabilize communities and rebuild social trust. Lao et al. (2024) conducted a study on former rebels in Davao del Sur and found that livelihood programs, psycho social support, and community acceptance were essential in facilitating their successful reintegration. The study emphasized that ex-combatants who received multidimensional support were more likely to reintegrate peacefully and contribute to local development (Lao et al., 2024). Reintegration therefore represents a bridge between negative and positive peace by ensuring that individuals formerly involved in violence can return as productive members of society. These findings align

with the broader understanding that peace is not merely the absence of conflict but the presence of mechanisms that promote healing, reconciliation, and long-term community resilience. Reintegration processes help reduce stigma, improve relationships, and foster shared responsibility for development—key indicators of positive social peace.

The fist theme, **Peace Among Children in Visual Representation,** explores how children use drawings and visual imagery to represent their early ideas of peace. Their visual expressions reveal emotional states, social experiences, and perceptions of harmony and conflict within their environments. The Second Theme, **Making Sense of Children's Visual Expressions of Social Peace** This theme focuses on how researchers interpret the meanings embedded in children's artwork. Colors, symbols, and composition provide insight into how children understand cooperation, fairness, safety, and peaceful relationships in their social world. The Third Theme, **Arts-Based Approaches to Peace Education** This theme discusses how creative activities such as painting, drawing, storytelling, and performance enhance peace education by fostering emotional expression, empathy, participation, and deeper engagement in peace-learning processes. The Fourth Theme, **Capturing Authentic Child Voices in Meaning-Making Through Audio Narratives** , This theme examines methods that use children's spoken stories and audio-recorded reflections to uncover how they think about social peace. These narratives provide authentic, child-centered perspectives that complement visual forms of expression. The fifth Theme, **Children's Artistic Expression of Social Peace ,**This theme highlights how children's artistic creations depict their views of harmony, kindness, and ideal social interactions. Through art-making, children construct and communicate their ideas of positive relationships and peaceful communities. The Sixth Theme, **Cultural Responsive and Community-Based Perspectives of Peace Education** This theme emphasizes that peace learning must be rooted in cultural identity, community values, and local traditions. It highlights the importance of indigenous perspectives, cultural relevance, and community engagement in shaping meaningful peace education.The Seventh Theme, **Children's Meaning-Making Through Symbols and Material Drawing Practices** This theme explores how children use symbols, materials, and drawing processes to construct meaning about social peace. Their choices in tools, textures, and symbolic elements reflect cognitive, emotional, and experiential understandings of peaceful living.

Peace in education has become increasingly important, as schools are seen as key places to build a culture of peace (Navarro & Castro, 2020). Research underscores that peace transcends mere absence of conflict, encompassing values such as justice, belonging, and cultural identity (Anderson & Nestrova, 2024).

Peace among Children in Visual Representation

Children often express what peace means to them through drawings, colors, and symbols that reveal both their personal experiences and their understanding of the world around them. According to Gulec (2021), children's artworks reflect not only their awareness of peace but also their exposure to war and conflict. Blasch and Thoma (2024) explain that integrating art-based reflection in peace education helps children think more deeply about what peace represents in their lives. Meanwhile, Deguara (2024) emphasizes that pairing children's drawings with narrative discussions allows educators to explore their perceptions more meaningfully. Cultural background plays a significant role in how children portray peace. Restoy et al. (2022) note that cultural factors must always be considered when interpreting children's artworks. Similarly, Ioannou et al. (2022) argue that children's visual expressions should be analyzed with both emotional and cultural sensitivity. Vettori et al. (2022) further reveal that children's drawings often mirror their emotional conditions and their sense of safety and security. Combining visual art and open discussion makes interpretations of children's peace imagery more reliable. Fabris et al. (2023) recommend engaging children in reflective conversations to better understand the meanings behind their art. Gulec (2021) also stresses the importance of conducting interviews to clarify the deeper intentions and emotions in children's visual expressions. Children's understanding of peace often begins with simple ideas such as harmony and the absence of war. Reyes and Bautista (2020) find that indigenous students associate peace with their connection to nature, tradition, and community. Nesterova and Anderson (2024) observe that many young people today connect peace with inclusion, equality, and environmental care. Haruna (2022) points out that drawings are a powerful way for displaced children to communicate messages of peace when words fall short. Anderson and Nesterova (2024) conclude that combining art-based practices like drawing, painting, and peace walks helps learners express their unique perceptions of harmony and cooperation.

Making Sense of Children's Visual Expressions of Social Peace

Social peace, defined as harmonious interpersonal relationships, cooperation, empathy, and the presence of social cohesion, has become an important focus of educational research. Children's drawings offer a valuable window into how young learners conceptualize and express social peace, as they provide symbolic and creative means for representing relationships, community, and positive interactions. Recent studies highlight that drawings serve not only as reflective tools but also as instruments for peace education, allowing children to communicate and internalize social values in a developmentally appropriate manner.

Güleç (2021) investigated children's perceptions of peace through drawings and interviews, revealing that children frequently represented peace as interpersonal harmony and relational well-being. Symbols such as hearts, smiling figures, flowers, and peace signs were commonly used to depict friendship, cooperation, and acts of care. Similarly, Deguara (2024) explored how students made meaning of peace and war through drawings, highlighting that even young children could represent complex social and emotional concepts. Children depicted safe, happy, and cooperative spaces, using colors, lines, and symbolic figures to communicate social harmony. Cornaggia et al. (2024) similarly reported that Italian children, when prompted to draw about peace in the context of the Ukraine war, favored bright colors and collaborative scenes, emphasizing relational and communal aspects of peace. These studies indicate that children's visual expressions of peace often center on interpersonal relationships, empathy, and collective well-being.

Art-based interventions have also demonstrated the pedagogical potential of drawing in fostering social peace. Khairuddin, Idrus, Razak, and Ismail (2023) implemented art activities in preschool settings in Malaysia to promote peace education, observing that children's drawings reflected themes of love, unity, cooperation, and social inclusion. Toklu and Amca (2024) similarly found that integrating drawing into early childhood peace education enhanced children's communication, social sensitivity, and peer relationships. These studies confirm that drawing can be an active tool to nurture social peace, as it allows children to process social experiences and

internalize relational values. The emotional and socio-cultural dimensions of children's drawings further contribute to understanding social peace. No (2024) examined drawings of children in conflict-affected contexts, highlighting that even in adverse situations, children included elements of social connection, care, and communal safety in their artworks. Mondragón, Idoiaga, and Capurso (2022) explored children's representations during COVID-19 lockdowns, revealing that drawings conveyed feelings of isolation as well as longing for social contact and cooperative interaction, emphasizing that children's understanding of social peace is linked to emotional security and relational continuity. Additionally, conceptual studies underscore the importance of relational and positive peace as a social process. Blasch (2024) analyzed children's drawings combined with textual descriptions, illustrating that children frame peace in terms of mutual care, collaboration, and inclusion, while Huxley (2025) argued that art-based pedagogies foster dialogical engagement, allowing children to negotiate meaning, empathize with others, and cultivate social cohesion. These findings align with the broader theoretical understanding that social peace is actively constructed through relationships and collaborative practices, rather than merely the absence of conflict.

Taken together, the literature indicates that children's drawings are not only reflective of their internalized ideas of social harmony but also serve as instruments for developing and expressing social peace. Through the use of lines, colors, symbols, and representational figures, children communicate relational understanding, empathy, and cooperative behaviors, which are central to social peace. Drawing emerges as both a research tool and an educational strategy to foster positive social interactions, communal awareness, and interpersonal well-being among children.

Arts-Based Approaches to Peace Education Programs

Arts-based strategies make peace education more participatory, creative, and meaningful. According to Anderson et al. (2024), artistic activities encourage active learning by allowing students to engage both cognitively and emotionally with the concept of peace. Similarly, Breed et al. (2022) explain that collaborative art-making fosters dialogue, trust, and mutual

understanding within communities. Bae-Dimitriadis (2024) emphasizes that integrating the arts into peace education promotes empathy and critical reflection, helping learners to better understand social harmony and conflict resolution. Dunne et al. (2023) further demonstrate that peace-centered pedagogy enhances students' academic performance while also cultivating their social and emotional awareness. Creative innovation also plays a key role in peacebuilding through visual expression. Moller and Bellmer (2023) introduce the concept of Interactive Peace Imagery (IPI), which encourages learners to visualize peace in collaborative and imaginative ways. Hazenberg et al. (2025) assert that the process of creating art together strengthens intergroup relationships, enhances trust, and promotes mutual respect among diverse participants.

In the Philippine context, the Teach Peace Build Peace Movement (2020) highlights that participation in artistic projects helps learners internalize peace values and apply them in daily life. The University of the Philippines (2024) also implements community-based art initiatives that promote awareness of justice, human rights, and social responsibility. Likewise, Breed et al. (2022) point out that co-created, art-based research fosters dialogue, emotional healing, and reconciliation in communities affected by conflict. At the classroom level, Bae-Dimitriadis (2024) proposes practical strategies for integrating the creative arts into peace education, while Jolyon (2020) emphasizes that artistic expression can serve as a tool for resolving interpersonal conflicts and nurturing understanding. Anderson et al. (2024) argue that creative approaches empower young people to become active peacebuilders through collaboration, reflection, and imagination. Similarly, Dunne et al. (2024) recommend the use of arts-based workshops that cultivate empathy, civic responsibility, and social participation. The Aesthetics of Peace Project (2024) underscores that creativity not only inspires individual reflection but also drives collective action toward peace. Paat et al. (2025) add that such initiatives contribute to civic learning, moral development, and violence prevention. On a broader scale, art has been proven to support emotional healing and trauma recovery. Nadam (2023) reports that art therapy promotes psychological recovery among refugees and war-affected individuals. Onuorah (2022) observes that art workshops in Nigeria enhance peace awareness among youth, fostering a culture of dialogue and tolerance. Holochwost et al. (2021) demonstrate that participation in artistic activities improves socio-emotional competence and empathy among students, while Khairuddin

(2023) notes that Malaysian learners develop values of cooperation, patience, and mutual respect through sustained artistic engagement.

Capturing Authentic Child Voices in Meaning-Making About Social Peace Through Audio--Recorded Narratives

Audio recording children's verbal explanations preserves the verbatim speech and thus reduces loss or distortion that occurs when researchers rely only on memory or hurried field notes (McMullin, 2021). Recordings enable researchers to re-listen a step that improves analytic depth because repeated listening reveals nuances and supports more careful coding decisions (Hill, 2022). Audio captures paralinguistic information (tone, pitch, pauses, laughter, speed) that often carries emotional meaning not present in transcripts alone and that can change interpretation of what a child says about a drawing (Guyer et al., 2021). Multi-modal approaches that triangulate transcript, audio and (when available) video data produce richer analysis because the aural channel adds layers of meaning beyond words on a page (Craig, McInroy, Goulden, & Eaton, 2021).

Narrative inquiry has become a valuable qualitative method for exploring students' personal experiences, beliefs, and values. This approach is especially useful when studying concepts like peace, which cannot be fully measured through surveys alone. As Rahmawati (2022) demonstrated in her narrative study with language learners, audio-recorded interviews allow participants to express their inner thoughts freely, making their stories more detailed and emotionally authentic. Recorded narratives preserve tone, pauses, emphasis, and emotion—elements that help researchers understand how students genuinely experience and interpret peace in their everyday lives. Several researchers have emphasized the importance of using narratives to explore peace-related experiences among youth. For instance, Bajaj and Hantzopoulos (2020) highlight that peace education is most effective when students share their own stories of conflict, cooperation, and reconciliation. Through recorded conversations, students describe how they define peace, how they deal with disagreements, and how their environment influences their sense of safety and harmony.

These narratives help researchers recognize patterns in students' behavior and understand the social conditions that shape their attitudes toward peace. Similarly, McGlynn et al. (2022) used narrative interviews to explore how students from conflict-affected communities perceive peacebuilding in schools. They found that students' recorded stories revealed not only their hopes for peaceful relationships but also the hidden fears, tensions, and biases that are not usually visible in quantitative studies. Audio recordings captured emotions and hesitations that signaled deeper feelings, making the data richer and more meaningful. This supports Rahmawati's argument that recorded narratives provide depth that written responses cannot offer. according to Martínez-Mesa et al., 2020 When Teachers choose participants based on convenience, perceived compliance, or academic performance, students with alternative experiences—such as those who have witnessed or experienced conflicts—may be excluded. This selective participation can skew the findings and fail to reflect the full spectrum of student perspectives on peace.

Comparative research shows that interviews conducted without recorders can sometimes produce usable data, but recording remains the best practice for preserving detail and for enabling later checks of accuracy and interpretation (Rutakumwa et al., 2020). Long-form and naturalistic audio research literature highlights both the value of high-fidelity audio for accessing subtle social behavior and the ethical responsibilities to manage consent, privacy, and data security carefully (Cychosz et al., 2020). Methodological reviews emphasize that transcription is not a neutral conversion; transcript decisions (e.g., intelligent vs. full verbatim) shape analysis, so keeping original audio allows researchers to check transcription choices and preserve analytic transparency (McMullin, 2021). Guidance on research with children recommends explicit, child-appropriate information about recording and where appropriate using audio as a consent/assent option when literacy or language barriers exist (Horowicz, 2023). Team or double-checking procedures (e.g., having a second researcher compare transcript to audio) increase dependability by reducing single-researcher bias in transcription and interpretation (Hill, 2022). Finally, recording and retaining audio files creates an audit trail that strengthens trustworthiness and allows reviewers or co-researchers to verify interpretation decisions during peer review or supervision (McMullin, 2021; Cychosz et al., 2020).

Children's Artistic Expression of Social Peace in Conflict-Affected Rural Areas

Students living in rural or conflict-affected areas are often exposed to violence, displacement, and social instability, which can affect their emotional, social, and cognitive development. Drawing and other creative arts have been identified as effective tools for children to express experiences, process trauma, and communicate their understanding of social peace.

Children's Drawings as Windows into Conflict Experiences Children in conflict zones use drawing to convey both traumatic experiences and social relationships. IDP children and non-displaced peers in Myanmar depicted relational aspects of their lives through symbols and figures, highlighting desires for social cohesion (Lokola, 2024). Art as a Therapeutic and Meaning-Making Tool Creative arts interventions support children's well-being and provide a platform for expressing social and emotional concerns (Buser, 2024). Art therapy with refugee children has been shown to foster empathy, social understanding, and resilience (Ramadan, 2024). Mask-making and projective drawing techniques allow children to communicate relational perspectives in conflict-affected settings (Green, 2019).

Expressing Social Peace and Relational Values even in conflict contexts, children often depict cooperation, friendship, and communal harmony through drawings (Denov, 2024). Children indirectly affected by conflict use drawings to represent safe and cooperative spaces, often employing bright colors and symbolic figures to express social harmony (Deguara, 2024). Participatory arts programs further enable children to actively contribute to peacebuilding, developing relational skills through collaborative creation (Paterson-Young, 2024). Children's Drawings as Indicators of Emotional and Social Resilience Drawings provide insight into children's socio-emotional functioning. Arts-based interventions in humanitarian settings strengthen psychosocial resilience while promoting social understanding (Frasco et al., 2025). Drawings by former child soldiers reflect trauma as well as hope and relational repair (Ahmad, 2024). The Bridge Drawing Test with refugee minors reveals how children express relational security and aspirations for community connection (Girsh, 2024). Contextual Evidence from Rural and Conflict-Affected Areas Field-based studies from the Philippines and Cameroon show that children in rural

conflict zones use drawing to depict both traumatic experiences and visions of social harmony (Gutang, 2024).

Children exposed to armed conflict or displacement employ drawing to communicate social and emotional realities (Denov, 2024). Creative arts in conflict zones facilitate dialogue, social cohesion, and children's sense of belonging (Davis, 2021). Participatory and Community-Oriented Approaches, children become agents of social peace when they collaboratively create artwork, negotiate meaning, and develop empathy (Breed et al., 2024). Arts-based interventions in conflict-affected communities foster dialogue, promote social cohesion, and strengthen relational skills (Paterson-Young, 2024). Systematic reviews show that art therapy effectively supports psychosocial well-being in conflict-affected and displaced children (Anous, Al-Hroub, & El Zein, 2022). Drawing and arts-based approaches also allow children to articulate aspirations for social harmony despite adverse contexts (Ahmad, 2024). Overall, the literature demonstrates that children's drawings in rural or conflict-affected areas reflect social relationships, community, and relational peace. Art provides both a reflective and therapeutic tool, allowing children to represent trauma, resilience, and hope. Participatory arts-based approaches empower children to contribute to social peace, empathy, and cooperation, justifying the use of drawings as a research method to study social peace in conflict-affected rural contexts (Deguara, 2024).

Policy and Institutional Frameworks of Peace Education

Institutional policies form the backbone of sustainable peace education. The Department of Education (2020) has declared schools as "zones of peace," embedding peacebuilding in educational policy. Despite this, Purwanto et al. (2023) note that arts-based learning remains limited in classroom practice. The Department of Education (2022) includes peace values in the national curriculum, but Purwanto et al. (2023) observes inconsistencies in implementation across universities. Floresta (2022) explains that the national framework integrates peace values throughout the education system. Macabato (2023) recommends adopting culturally responsive teaching strategies to make peace education more inclusive. The Commission on Higher Education (2024) also provides guidelines for embedding peace education in tertiary programs.

Sapao and Dacles (2023) note that even with limited resources, teachers creatively use visual materials like posters and short films to promote peace in classrooms.

These policies align with the Philippine Development Plan (2020), which recognizes peace and justice as national goals. However, Mabunga (2016) stresses that challenges remain, including inconsistent implementation and lack of institutional support. Continuous evaluation and stronger partnerships between educators and policymakers are needed to fully integrate peace education nationwide.

Recent empirical and conceptual research underscores the increasing institutionalization of peace education at multiple levels. Khan (2019) show how secondary-school curricula and teacher practices begin to integrate peace education, pointing to both opportunities and challenges for institutional adoption. Institutional frameworks are further elaborated at the teacher-education level: Mabunga's (2022) study on UNESCO-ASPnet member TEIs demonstrates that administrators, faculty, and students view peace education positively, offering a workable framework for teacher training institutions. At the school-division level, Sapao & Dacles (2021) document how peace-education policies translate into what they term a "peace culture," suggesting institutionalization beyond mere curricular insertion. In post-conflict contexts, local governance matters: Zainal et al. (2021) reveal that, even where local governments attempt to embed peace education in secondary schools, normative and sociological challenges (e.g., religious or national curricula priorities) may limit effective implementation. In higher education, Millican et al. (2021) argue passionately for embedding peace building pedagogies at HEIs, illustrating how institutional structures, curricula, and teacher training converge. National-level policy frameworks are also under critical evaluation: Tumamin et al. (2024) examine how a formal "Schools as Zones of Peace" policy plays out in Philippine secondary schools, revealing gaps in governance and outcomes. Broader structural critiques such as Akar (2024) show that institutional failures, political gridlock, and governance deficits often hamper the potential of education to contribute to sustainable peace in conflict-affected nations. Finally, bibliometric evidence (Istianah et al., 2024) confirms an upward trend in peace-education scholarship globally, reflecting growing institutional and academic commitment.

Cultural Responsive and Community-Based Perspectives on Peace Education

Peace education must reflect the cultural, social, and environmental realities of each community. Olivilius and Akebo (2021) assert that programs are most effective when adapted to local traditions and values. Lokola (2024) adds that marginalized groups are often excluded from peace efforts, calling for more inclusive and equitable frameworks. Delos Reyes and Santos (2023) demonstrate that contextualized art practices, such as using indigenous symbols, can promote cultural understanding and social harmony. Nguyen et al. (2020) highlight that visual methodologies like drawing and photography foster emotional and cognitive engagement with peace concepts. Galtung (2021) expands the idea of peace by defining it as both social and environmental equity. Millican et al. (2021) stress the role of higher education in cultivating civic responsibility and peace-oriented values. Smieszek (2022) links peace education with climate justice, while Castle (2025) describes peace as an active, participatory process that requires ongoing dialogue and cooperation. Glowacki (2022) warns that peace initiatives can unintentionally create tension if underlying inequalities are ignored.

Paterson (2024) finds that local mediation efforts reduce community violence and strengthen cooperation. The Philippine Framework of Peace (2023) provides a foundation for understanding peace within local contexts. Savelyeva and Park (2024) argue that environmental education fosters both personal and collective peace, while O'Connor and Hearn (2023) show that visual arts empower youth to express their roles as peacebuilders. Bellmer and Moller (2023) identify images as neutral spaces for intercultural dialogue, and Restoy et al. (2022) highlight the influence of culture on how children visually represent peace.

St Andrews Project (2023) shows that involving students in participatory art projects increases their engagement and sense of inclusion. Castle (2025) explains that peace begins in the home and community through empathy, cooperation, and respect. Mendoza and Flor (2021) observe that participatory visual activities such as drawing, and photography allow young people to express peace imaginatively. Mabunga (2016) finds that local peacebuilding initiatives help strengthen communities and prevent violence. Holochwost et al. (2021) note that children's drawings reveal their emotions and understanding of peace, making them valuable tools for

educators. Langhout et al. (2021) show that digital photovoice projects empower youth to share their visions of peace and collective action online. Finally, Comics as Peace Pedagogy for Children (2023) concludes that comics effectively teach empathy, cooperation, and respect through visual storytelling.

Children's Meaning-Making Through Symbolic and Material Drawing Practices

Children's drawings have been widely examined in educational and psychological research as meaningful tools through which young learners interpret and communicate complex social concepts such as war, peace, conflict, and interpersonal relationships. Recent scholarships emphasize that children's meaning-making is shaped not only by what they draw, but also by the materials, symbols, and processes involved in their drawing activities. One important dimension of this process is the drawing surface provided to children.

Children's drawings are widely recognized as powerful semiotic tools through which young people communicate internal states, social understandings, and experiences that may be difficult to articulate verbally. Yu and Nagai (2020) demonstrate that children's use of visual elements such as line quality, color choices, shapes, and compositional balance mirrors their psychological development and evolving self-perception. This indicates that the visual decisions children make are meaningful, not random. Research in adverse contexts reinforces this interpretive value. Goldner, Lev-Wiesel, and Binson (2021) found that children who experienced abuse frequently embedded symbolic cues in their drawings, including dark shapes, distorted figures, or protective barriers, which reflected fear, relational stress, or attempts to assert safety. Similarly, cultural-semiotic analysis by Kelly and Green (2024) shows that children construct meaning through their visual grammar; they use spatial arrangement, emphasis, and symbolic elements to express what they consider significant within their social worlds. These findings highlight drawing as a meaning-making practice shaped by cultural and interpersonal experience. Studies linking drawing to resilience further deepen this understanding. A 2023 participatory visual study from the University of Chester found that adolescents used recurring visual motifs

such as connected figures, shields, or elevated characters to represent strength, supportive relationships, and emotional endurance.

Beyond the drawings themselves, narrative explanation enhances interpretive clarity. A study published in Frontiers in Education (2025) demonstrated that when children narrate their drawings, they align visual design elements (lines, spatial emphasis, and character placement) with story structure and emotional themes, indicating that drawing is a multimodal meaning-making practice. Additional evidence indicates that children's visual choices also reflect broader developmental and identity processes, as seen in an MDPI study (2022) analyzing children's paintings transformed into public artworks; the authors observed that composition and color patterns corresponded with self-concept, emotional tone, and environmental influences.

Deguara (2024) found that plain drawing paper remains a preferred and effective medium for eliciting children's expressions of war and peace. Its flexibility allows children to freely create lines, symbols, and color variations, enabling them to externalize their ideas without structural constraints. The simplicity of paper supports nuanced expression, making it an accessible platform for children to articulate complex emotional and conceptual understandings. The tools children use also influence their expressive capacities. According to Güleç (2021), children commonly employ basic art materials such as crayons and colored pencils when representing themes related to peace. These easily accessible tools facilitate the creation of recognizable icons of hearts, flowers, and peace signs that serve as symbolic representations of children's social, emotional, and moral perspectives.

Such symbolic forms allow children to communicate abstract concepts through familiar imagery. Minimalist drawing tools, particularly pencils, have also been identified as significant within research contexts. The article Drawing as a Space for Social-Cognitive Interaction (Education Sciences, 2022) argues that simple line drawing reduces emphasis on artistic skill and instead foregrounds children's cognitive and social processes. Through line work, children engage in shared thinking, negotiation of ideas, and reflection on social experiences. Thus, the drawing process itself becomes a space for social-cognitive interaction rather than merely a production of visual artifacts. Color is another central component of meaning-making in children's artwork. A study published in Ricerche di Psicologia (2025) reports that children typically use brighter,

more varied colors when drawing themes related to peace, while depictions of war tend to contain darker or muted tones. This contrast reflects an emotional and symbolic distinction: warm, colorful palettes are associated with hope, harmony, and positivity, whereas subdued colors evoke conflict, fear, or tension. Color therefore operates as an emotional language through which children differentiate experiences and perspectives related to peace and war. Finally, research underscores the symbolic significance of lines, shapes, and imagery in children's depictions of conflict and harmony.

Deguara (2024) notes that children employ diverse representational tools—such as depictions of weapons, protective figures, or natural environments to convey their understandings of conflict, safety, and peace. These visual elements function as symbolic devices that reveal children's internal representations and emotional responses to social issues. The combination of lines, colors, and shapes creates a visual narrative that expresses both the intensity and complexity of children's concepts of war and peace.

Implications to the study

The examination of pertinent literature reveals that peace is not solely an abstract or political notion but a tangible experience intricately linked to human relationships, emotions, and culture. Research indicates that peace can be perceived, experienced, and articulated in various forms, including art, communal practices, quotidian acts of empathy, and collaboration. The most important thing to remember is that peace is not just the absence of conflict; it is also the creation of safe, harmonious, and welcoming spaces where people, especially young people, can thrive.

Young people are not just passive learners; they are storytellers, artists, and active builders of peace. Their drawings, colors, and symbols are more than just creative works; they are visual representations of their hopes, fears, and understanding of the world around them. These visual expressions have emotional depth and cultural significance, revealing how students view peace in their families, communities, and country. Art thus becomes a medium of peace through which students articulate their identity and aspirations for a harmonious society.

In line with the study's objectives, these insights underscore the importance of examining how students visually depict peace and nation-building, interpreting the symbols they employ, and convey meanings through narratives and imagery. This study addresses a significant gap by focusing on visual representations to deepen and critically examine understanding of adolescents' perspectives on peace in educational contexts. This focus also supports the goal of developing helpful suggestions to improve peace education through arts-based and participatory methods.

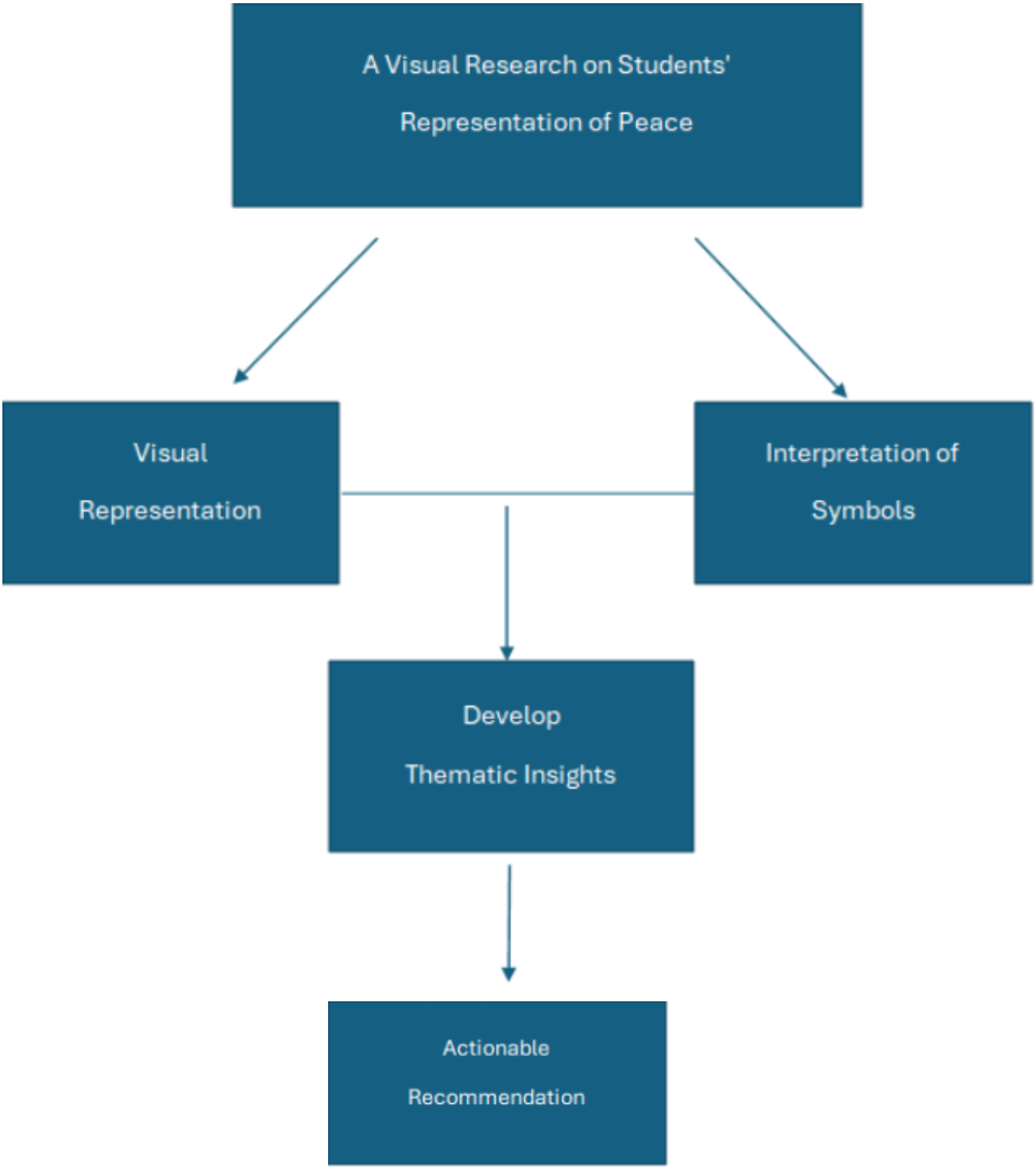
1.3 Theoretical Framework

The research will utilize Symbolic Interactionism. George Herbert Mead developed a theory, and Herbert Blumer later organized it into a system. This framework is especially adept at elucidating how individuals ascribe meaning to abstract concepts like peace, articulated symbolically through language, gestures, and visual representations.

Symbolic Interactionism asserts that individuals behave according to the meanings objects and situations hold for them, which are formed through social interactions and continually altered through a process of interpretation (Blumer, 1969). The theory underscores the importance of symbols as fundamental instruments for communication and for constructing meaning construction in social contexts. Utilizing the lens of symbolic interactionism, this study explores students' visual representation of peace, focusing on how learners conceptualize and communicate the notion of peace through visual media. Every student forms their understanding of peace through individual experiences, cultural contexts, and social interactions. These meanings are subsequently externalized through drawings.

This theoretical framework facilitates a comprehensive examination of the formation, dissemination, and potential transformation of peace meanings. It elucidates how students' representations may embody overarching social values, ideologies, and conflicts, and how these are navigated through symbolic manifestations of peace. Students are not simply portraying peace as a universal or immutable concept. Instead, they are actively creating meaning. This research employs Symbolic Interactionism to elucidate the variations in students' interpretations of peace, the social factors that influence these interpretations, and how visual representations function as communicative acts that both reflect and construct social reality.

1.4 Conceptual Framework



1.5 Statement of the Problem/Objectives of the Study

This study aims to explore how students conceptualize and express the ideas of peace through visual art. Specifically, It seeks to:

1. Analyze the students' interpretation of their visual representation of peace

2. Interpret the symbolism and meanings embedded in students' visuals;

3. Develop thematic insights from students' narratives to explain their visual representation; and

4. Provide actionable recommendations to strengthen peace education programs within the institution.

1.6 Scope and Limitations

This case study examines the visual representation of peace among students, specifically analyzing the symbols, meanings, and themes that arise from their visual and narrative expressions. The research aims to comprehend how students conceptualize peace through their creative expressions and how peace education is manifested in their representations.

Similarly, the study participants will be restricted to criminology students enrolled in a course that incorporates peace education principles. Criminology students will be selected as participants because their academic curriculum directly engages with principles of peace, justice, order, and social responsibility. Specifically, second-year criminology students are enrolled in General Education Courses (GECs), some of which include peace education, thereby enhancing their understanding of peace and nation-building. The study is limited to a single institution, as it is a single-case study. The locale is a private higher education institution situated within the municipality; therefore, the results may not accurately represent the perspectives of students from other colleges or regions.

Lastly, the study only examines visual art and the stories that accompany it. Other forms of expression, like performance art or essays without pictures, were not included.

1.7 Definition of Terms

To ensure conceptual precision and clarity, in the use of terms, which are operationally defined for this study, the following terms were used:

1. **Peace Among Children in Visual Representation.** Children's drawings and images that show how they understand and imagine peace.
2. **Children's Visual Expressions of Social Peace.** The meanings in children's artwork that reflect their ideas about harmony, fairness, and positive relationships.
3. **Arts-Based Approaches to Peace Education.** Using creative activities like drawing, painting, and storytelling to teach peace and encourage emotional expression.
4. **Audio-Recorded Child Narratives.** Children's spoken stories and explanations about peace captured through audio recordings.
5. **Children's Artistic Expression of Social Peace.** Artworks children create that show their views of kindness, cooperation, and peaceful social interactions.
6. **Culturally Responsive and Community-Based Peace Education.** Peace education that reflects local culture, community values, and indigenous perspectives.
7. **Meaning-Making Through Symbols and Drawing Practices.** How children use symbols, materials, and drawing processes to express and explore their ideas about peace.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter presents the research design, locale, respondents, research instruments, ethical standards, data gathering procedure, and data analysis plan. These components collectively describe the systematic process that guided the conduct of the study

2.1 Research Design

This study will utilize a qualitative visual research design, allowing students to articulate their perceptions of peace through drawing. This design is ideal as it empowers participants to creatively express their internal perspectives and authentic experiences. This study will use a qualitative visual research design to explore how students visually represent and interpret the concept of peace through drawings and narratives.

In this study, the qualitative visual research design is used to capture students' symbolic and creative expression of peace. It emphasizes the use of visual materials specifically, drawings as a primary source of data, complemented by participants' explanations and reflections about their artwork. This approach aligns with the **Interactive Peace Imagery (IPI)** framework of Moller and Bellmer (2023), which encourages learners to visualize peace as a participatory and interactive process. Through qualitative research design, the researchers aim to highlight students' authentic voices and creative perspectives.

2.2 Research Materials and Methods

This study will utilize a qualitative visual research instrument derived from the Interactive Peace Imagery (IPI) framework established by Moller and Bellmer (2023). The tool has two main parts: a drawing activity and a guided reflection. Participants will convey their understanding of peace both visually and verbally. Subsequently, they will elucidate its significance and articulate their personal and academic interpretations of peace.

The participants are criminology students enrolled in The Contemporary World course. Participants were intentionally selected due to their enrollment in a course that incorporates peace education concepts, thus rendering their perspectives directly pertinent to the study's objective.

The data collection will be conducted through a series of structured yet participatory activities. Before these activities commence, the researchers will obtain permission from the school and the department, as well as consent from all participants. The data will be gathered via a classroom drawing activity based on the Interactive Peace Imagery framework (Moller & Bellmer, 2023). Participants present drawings illustrating their conceptualization of peace, which is then followed by a short period of verbal reflection and discussion on their artwork. The researchers will collect the drawings and accompanying reflections for subsequent qualitative analysis, while safeguarding the participant's confidentiality, and ensuring ethical data utilization throughout the process.

2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

Research Locale

The setting for this study is a private higher education institution situated in a municipality that provides education at the elementary, secondary, and tertiary levels. It is a higher education institution that offers a general education curriculum. It does not have a peace course, but it does include peace education in one of its general education courses. The Roman Catholic Diocese of Butuan runs this private school. The main campus is on Atupan Street in Barangay 4, Nasipit, Agusan del Norte. The second campus, on the other hand, is in Barangay Triangulo and houses the Elementary and Senior High School Department.

Research Participants

The participants in this study are second-year criminology students from Saint Michael College of Caraga. The selection of the Bachelor of Science in Criminology (BSCRIM) students is appropriate because their academic training equips them with foundational knowledge.

Criminology education in the Philippines is designed to produce professionals who contribute directly to public safety, peace, and order. The Philippine Criminology Profession Act of 2018 (RA 11131) formally recognizes criminologists as key actors in maintaining national security, public safety, and peacebuilding (Philippine Legislature, 2019). In addition to the legal framework, criminology students are institutionally prepared to serve as future peace officers through partnerships between higher education institutions and law enforcement agencies. For instance, memoranda of agreement between universities and the Philippine National Police (PNP) enable criminology students to participate in structured training programs that familiarize them with policing procedures, community engagement, and investigative responsibilities.

. These experiences enable them to critically analyze peace and social order. Additionally, the researchers selected them because they are enrolled in a General Education Course (GEC 5) The Contemporary World that included peace education. As a future law enforcers and peace advocates, their viewpoints provide significant insights into the internalization and expression of peace within the field of criminology.

Moreover, the inclusion criteria for the participants in this study are the BS Criminology students particularly those residing in rural Barangays in Simbalan and Hinandayan. Which is influenced by the insurgency coming from rural areas with exposure to armed conflict which will bring firsthand perspectives on how conflict is experienced and how peace is imagined in community settings. These rural contexts often face issues related to social order, territorial disputes, and limited access to formal peace keeping structures, making residents more attuned to everyday experiences of peace, insecurity, and community cooperation. Their lived context enriches the study by providing grounded insights that align with research showing that peace imagery is shaped by personal and environmental experiences (Haruna, 2020).

PAMANA development program in conflict affected barangays showed that peace building initiatives can only be assessed properly by collecting authentic data from communities living through insurgency and instability (Deluna, 2024).

Meanwhile, the exclusion criteria are those students who have never lived in the identified rural barangays, students who are not enrolled in (GEC 5). Lastly, the withdrawal criteria

are for those students who are currently experiencing severe emotional or psychological distress as determined by the guidance personnel are excluded from the study

Research Sampling

The researchers will use purposive sampling, the selecting participants based on specific criteria relevant to the study's objectives. The participants will consist ofcriminology students who are currently enrolled in General Education Course (GEC 5). Additionally, students from rural barangays (Simbalan and Hinandayan) selected through purposive sampling. This sample is justified because BSCRIM students have academic training in conflict management, community safety, and restorative justice, which equips them to meaningfully engage in visual and narrative exercises about social peace.. Under Republic Act 11131 The Philippine Criminology Profession Act, criminologist is recognized as critical actors in "national security, public safety, and nation building and development. Furthermore, students from these rural communities provide authentic perspectives based on lived experiences of local social tensions and community dynamics.

Inclusion Criteria: Participants are BSCRIM students, residing in the identified barangays, and willing to participate in the drawing and audio-recorded narrative activities.

Exclusion Criteria: Students who have never lived in these barangays are unwilling or unable to participate.

Research Instrument

The primary research instrument of this study is a qualitative visual research tool following the Interactive Peace Imagery (IPI) framework developed by Moller and Bellmer (2023). This instrument is designed to gather both visual and narrative data from participants, allowing them to express their understanding of peace through creative and reflective processes.

The instrument consists of two main components: The first component is a drawing activity, which allows participants to visually express their perceptions, experiences, and

understanding of social peace, conflict, and community dynamics. The second component is a guided reflection (or guide questions), which consist of structured research-made guide questions to use during Focus Group Discussion. They are provided with basic art materials such as paper, pencils, and coloring tools. The activity encourages free expression without strict artistic guidelines.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

Data Gathering Procedure

The study will collect qualitative data in the form of transcribed responses obtained through semi-structured interviews. This data will consist of the participants' detailed experiences, perceptions, and opinions relevant to the research questions.

The data collection will follow a systematic, multi-stage process to ensure ethical compliance and proper access to the research participants:

1. Institutional and Ethical Clearance

Initial Approval: A formal letter seeking permission to conduct the study will be prepared and submitted to the Dean for initial endorsement.

High-Level Approval: Upon endorsement, the letter will be submitted to the Vice President for Academic Affairs and Research (VPAAR) and the School President for final institutional approval to access the SMCC Community and conduct research within the premises.

Departmental Approval: Permission will then be sought from the respective Deans of the College of Criminal Justice Education (CCJE) and the College of Arts and Sciences (CAS) to gain access to their students.

2. Participant Identification and Selection

Collaboration with Instructors: The researchers will approach the Instructor of the relevant course/subject to discuss the study's objectives and collaborate on identifying potential participants.

Screening and Recruitment: The Instructor will assist in generating a list of students who meet the pre-established inclusion criteria. Potential participants will be contacted, informed about the study's purpose, confidentiality, and their right to withdraw, and then invited to participate. Informed Consent Forms will be administered and signed by all participants prior to data collection.

3. Interview and Data Recording

Interview Conduct: Semi-structured interviews will be conducted with the selected participants in a mutually agreed-upon private and comfortable setting. A pre-approved interview guide will be used to ensure consistency across all interviews.

Data Recording: With the participant's explicit permission recorded on the consent form, the interviews will be audio-recorded using a reliable digital device to capture the responses accurately.

Note-Taking: Simultaneously, the researchers will take field notes to capture non-verbal cues and contextual details that may enrich the analysis.

The collected data will be analyzed using Reflexive Thematic Analysis (RTA) as outlined by Clark and Braun (2006). RTA is a flexible and rigorous method for identifying, analyzing, and reporting patterns (themes) within data.

Data Analysis

This study will utilize a qualitative visual research design, specifically employing Reflexive Thematic Analysis (RTA) as articulated by Braun and Clarke (2006). This method helps examine how students visually and narratively convey their comprehension of peace, enabling researchers to discern, interpret, and reflect recurring patterns of meaning within the data.

The analysis will consist of six stages of Reflexive Thematic Analysis:

1. **Familiarization with the Data:** The researchers will thoroughly examine the students' artworks and narratives multiple times to fully comprehend their viewpoints on peace.

2. **Generating Initial Codes**—Important visual elements, symbols, colors, and words from the stories will be identified and systematically coded to capture key aspects of the data.
3. **Searching for Themes**: The researchers will group codes into possible themes that show how participants share meanings and ideas (e.g., peace as harmony, justice, community, or healing).
4. **Reviewing Themes**: The first themes will be refined and checked to ensure they accurately reflect the data and participants' visual and verbal expressions.
5. **Defining and Naming Themes**: Each derived theme will be clearly defined and concisely named to convey its primary meaning and its direct relevance to the study's goals. This process is particularly crucial for elucidating how criminology students conceptualize and articulate the notion of peace.
6. **Writing the Report:** The last step will be to put the themes together into a clear story, using examples from art and participants' thoughts to support it. The report will connect the results to other peace education research and information about the situation.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

This study will adhere to ethical standards throughout the research process. Before the study can begin, the school administration must give permission. Everyone will have to sign a consent form, and participation will be optional.

A. The Iintellectual Property Rights (IPR)

The researchers will ensure that all ideas, images, and written work created by participants are appropriately credited. To protect intellectual property rights, any secondary sources, such as literature and frameworks, will be cited in accordance with APA style.

B. Informed Consent

Participants will be fully informed about the purpose of the study, the drawing activity, the audio recording of their explanations, and how their data will be used, their right to withdraw.

A written informed consent form will be provided and explained before participation. Students under 18 (if any) will require both parental consent and participant assent. Only those who voluntarily sign the consent form will be allowed to join.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

All drawings, transcripts, and recordings will be stored securely in password-protected digital folders accessible only to the research team. No real names will appear in any report; instead, pseudonyms or codes will be used. Audio recordings will be deleted after transcription and verification. Data will not be shared with anyone outside the study and will be destroyed after the required retention period.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

Participation is fully voluntary. Students may refuse to answer any question, pause the activity, or withdraw from the study at any time without penalty or academic consequence. Their academic standing and relationship with instructors will not be affected by their decision. Students will be given refreshments during the conduct of the FGD and the drawing session.

E. Minimization of Harm

Topics of peace and conflict may trigger emotional discomfort especially among students living in rural communities with exposure to local conflict (Simbalan, and Hinandayan) the study includes strict protective measures. A licensed guidance counselor from the campus Guidance Center will be contacted or notified during data collection for psychological support. Participants will be reminded they may withdraw if they feel uneasy. A structured debriefing will follow each session, and anyone showing emotional distress will be referred for follow-up counseling. These measures minimize potential harm and ensure participant safety.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

Participation in this study offers direct and indirect benefits to the students. Directly, the drawing and narrative activities provide an opportunity for self-reflection, emotional expression,

and personal insight into concepts of social peace and conflict resolution. These findings can inform future peace-building programs, curriculum design, and arts-based interventions in criminology and related disciplines. By linking participants' lived experiences with scholarly analysis, the research adds value to both theory and practice, highlighting the role of students as active contributors to understanding and fostering social peace.

G. Justice and Fair Participation

Participant selection follows the principle of fairness, ensuring that individuals are included based on the study's objectives and not due to vulnerability or convenience. The sample included in the study (BSCRIM students) from rural sitios (Simbalan and hinandayan) are chosen because their experiences with armed conflict provide relevant perspectives not because they are disadvantaged. All participants will be treated equitably and respectfully.

H. Data Integrity Accuracy

The researchers will transcribe narratives accurately, interpret drawings systematically using established visual analysis frameworks, and avoid altering or omitting information to fit expectations. All findings whether supporting or contradicting assumptions will be reported truthfully. Any limitations or challenges encountered in the research process will also be disclosed.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The researchers commit to reporting procedures, findings, limitations, and challenges truthfully. No data will be fabricated, altered, or misrepresented. Interpretations of drawings and narratives will be based on systematic analysis and established frameworks, not personal biases. Any revisions made during the research process will be documented transparently.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

The study will not copy or reproduce copyrighted images, artworks, or proprietary materials without permission. When models, frameworks, or visual analysis tools are borrowed from published authors, proper citation and acknowledgment will be provided. All images used in the study will come solely from participants and will not involve copyrighted artwork.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

The study follows ethical guidelines for human research: no deception will be used, risks are minimal, and participants' dignity and autonomy are prioritized. Data collection involves only low-risk activities such as drawing and storytelling, with mental health protection measures in place.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Related Technologies

AI tools can be used to check grammar or organize references, but they won't change participants' data. The researchers will review all AI-assisted outputs to ensure they are original and adhere to academic standards. AI tools will only be used for non-sensitive tasks such as grammar checking or coding assistance. No participant drawings, photos, names, voices, or audio recordings will be uploaded to AI platforms to prevent privacy breaches.

We will be use the following:

Chatgpt: Assist drafting, summarizing, and refining text

Grammarly: for grammar and language checks

Atlas ti: supports coding and thematic analysis of qualitative data. But, researcher interpretation remains central to analysis.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Before implementation, the study will secure approval from the Institutional Ethics Review Committee, the Program Chair, the Dean, and the Guidance Center. Data collection will only begin upon receiving all required clearances.